

I do hate the bilge and bunkum about composers trying to “add” to a poem; that a fine poem is complete in itself, and to set it is only to gild the lily, and so on. It’s the sort of cliché which goes on being repeated (rather like the phrase “but art is above natural boundaries”). I rather expected it [over the settings of the two Milton Sonnets] and expect it still more when the Intimations [of Immortality] is finished. But alas, composers can’t rush into print, particularly where their own works are concerned - (though I do sometimes have a sneaking wish that editors would ask for one’s opinion!). Obviously a poem may be unsatisfactory in itself for setting, but that is a purely musical consideration - that it has no architectural possibilities: no broad vowels where climaxes should be, and so on. But the first and last thing is that a composer is (presumably) moved by a poem and wishes to identify himself with it and share it. Whether he is moved by a good or bad poem is beside the question. John [Herbert Sumsion] hit the nail on the head the other day when we were going through a dreadful biblical cantata, which X had sent him.... John said, “He chose his text, it didn’t choose him”. I don’t think everyone realizes the difference between choosing a text and being chosen by one.<sup>1</sup>

(Gerald Finzi, from a letter to Howard Ferguson)

Gerald Finzi’s vocal compositions demonstrate that he did indeed understand the distinction between choosing a text and being chosen by one. Finzi was first and foremost a lover of poetry. His lifelong friend Howard Ferguson had said that “English poetry was probably [Finzi’s] deepest interest.”<sup>2</sup>

Finzi’s affinity for song composition stemmed from his love of poetry. Finzi was exceptionally well read. His personal library of over 4,000 volumes is now permanently housed in the Finzi Room at the University of Reading. The majority of those volumes are editions of English poetry. Among the English poets whom Finzi read and loved, one stands above the rest as a

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<sup>1</sup> Curtis Alan Scheib, “Gerald Finzi’s Songs for Baritone on Texts by Thomas Hardy” (D.M.A. diss, West Virginia University, 1999): 18.

<sup>2</sup> Trevor Hold, *Parry to Finzi: Twenty English Song Composers* (Woodbridge: The Boydell Press, 2002): 397.

writer with whom the composer could especially identify. Of his *oeuvre* of sixty-four completed songs for solo voice and piano, forty-four are settings of Thomas Hardy's poetry.

Even from the earliest days of Finzi's short life, Thomas Hardy was a close literary inspiration. He began to feel a rapport with Hardy and his poems in his late teens, and his devotion lasted his entire life. In his survey of English song composers, Trevor Hold observed:

The poetry of Thomas Hardy preoccupied Finzi's creative imagination throughout his life. Except for the setting of Robert Graves's ballad, 'The cupboard' (1922) Finzi's first published work was the Hardy song cycle *By Footpath and Stile*, op. 2 (1921-2), for baritone and string quartet; one of his last completed compositions was 'I said to love', dated 12th July 1956, only two months before his death.<sup>3</sup>

During his lifetime, Finzi published, in addition to *By Footpath and Stile*, three sequences of Hardy settings, of ten songs each: *A Young Man's Exhortation* (1926-9) for tenor and piano, *Earth and Air and Rain* (1928-32) for baritone and piano, and *Before and After Summer* (1932-49) also for baritone and piano. He had intended to publish at least two more volumes of ten songs each, although, at his death, neither was completed. Those songs in finished state were published posthumously in two sets, one for tenor, *Till Earth Outwears* (1958: seven songs), and one for baritone, *I Said to Love* (1958: six songs). Finzi was keenly aware of his fondness for setting Hardy poetry and wrote about it on a few occasions. In a letter to his wife, Joy, later recorded in her journal, Finzi penned: "I have... from [my] earliest days responded, not so much to an influence as to a kinship with him (I don't mean a kinship to his genius, alas, but with his mental makeup)."<sup>4</sup> In 1949 Finzi wrote the following to Edmund Blunden: "Alas I never knew Thomas

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<sup>3</sup> Hold: 400.

<sup>4</sup> Christopher Stunt, "Hardy & Finzi," (An adaptation of his BA Special Hons dissertation, University of Bristol, 1996), *The Clock of the Years: A Gerald and Joy Finzi Anthology*, ed. Rolf Jordan (Lichfield: Chosen Press, 2007): 154.

Hardy except through his work, and that has been to me what the Bible must have been to Bunyan.”<sup>5</sup>

Thomas Hardy was born on 2 June, 1840, to a father who was a stonemason and a mother who was brought up on parish relief. Hardy’s parents were unmarried at his conception. Having attended the local schools of rural Dorset, his education was severely limited, causing Hardy to become an autodidact. He had an early interest in architecture, thanks to the work of his father. His mother instilled in Hardy a love of reading and writing. He was brought up in a conventional church-going family, but ceased to believe in the Anglican theology in his mid-twenties. His loss of faith thoroughly affected his individual view of the world and the image of it conveyed in his novels and poetry.

After leaving school, Hardy served as apprentice to John Hicks, an architect in Dorchester. His principal duty was surveying and measuring churches to be restored. During this period, Hardy wrote first-known work: A poem called *Domicillium*, in bereavement over the death of his grandmother. He taught himself Greek and became increasingly skilled in Latin. He also continued his study of classical and English literature. Of particular interest and influence were novelists/poets George Meredith and Algernon Charles Swinburne, both of whom represented at the time the more avant-garde and revolutionary element in English society. Hardy continued to write poetry, but editors rejected his earlier attempts at publication. His first publication, originally written for his colleagues, was a satirical sketch on architects and their clients: *How I Build Myself a House*.

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<sup>5</sup> Quoted by Andrew Burn, in an article about Finzi’s home at Ashmansworth for *Country Life*, 16 July 1987.

In the early 1870s, Hardy, frustrated with his failure to publish poetry, turned to novels. After an early struggle, this period saw the publication of several successful novels: *Desperate Remedies*, *Under the Greenwood Tree* and *Far From the Madding Crowd*. Several traits that came to be typical of his style emerged at this time. These include his love for animals and nature, his strong, nostalgic sense of past history, and drawing on characterizations and events from his own life.

Between the late 1870s and 1880s, Hardy published several more novels and collections of short stories, including *The Return of the Native*, *The Mayor of Casterbridge*, *Tess of the d'Urbervilles*, *Jude the Obscure* and *Well-Beloved*. Although his novels had always been received with varying degrees of criticism, when *Well-Beloved* was excoriated following its publication, Hardy was infuriated and returned to poetry, never to write another novel.

His novels contained characters that mirrored many of his own traits and his ideology: General disillusionment, rejection of the church, social insecurity, sensitivity to criticism, love of music, animals and nature, and specifically a strong belief in the dominion of fate.

Hardy's re-emergence as a poet was a "rebirth of sorts of his creative impulse,"<sup>6</sup> but it also coincided with the disintegration of his relationship with his wife, Emma Lavinia Gifford. He began to show an increased interest in other women, especially Florence Dugdale, a close friend and confidant of Emma. Emma died in 1912, causing in Hardy monumental feelings of contrition for his neglect of her. Hardy's remorse inspired much of his late poetry and reinforced his already present theme of the fragility of time and the dominance of death and fate in Hardy's writings. Florence Dugdale, despite Hardy's re-emergent love for his late wife, agreed to marry

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<sup>6</sup> Scheib: 29.

him two years after Emma's death. Hardy died at the age of 88 on 11 January, 1928 after dictating his final poem to Florence on his deathbed.

The subject matter and style of Hardy's *oeuvre complète* remained relatively unchanged throughout his life. Many poems published in the 1920s were written as early as the 1870s. Many of Hardy's topics are rooted in emotional nostalgia. Some recurrent themes include the contrast between the present and the idyllic past, memories of emotional moments between men and women, autobiographical references, thoughts of Emma, the beauty of nature, and a demoralized awareness of the human condition. Christopher Stunt, author of *Hardy & Finzi*, observed: "It seems that he needed to wait until he was in his sixties and seventies in order to write so challengingly about the great universal themes of Life and Death, the unreasonableness of Love, the irrationality of Nature, and the ruthless dominion of Time."<sup>7</sup>

Hardy's reputation rested on his novels, but he considered himself a poet. Poetry framed his literary works. For Hardy, the poetic medium was not so much about the beauty of the words as it was about the best vehicle for authentic expression. He explained:

For my own part I think—though not all writers will agree with me—that the shortest way to good prose is by the route of good verse. The apparent paradox—I cannot remember who first expressed it—that the best poetry is the best prose ceases on examination to be a paradox and becomes a truism. Anybody may test it for himself by taking any fine lines in verse and, casting off the fetters of metre and rhyme that seem to blind the poet, trying to express the same idea more freely and accurately in prose. He will find that it cannot be done: the words of the verse—fettered as he thought them—are the only words that will convey the ideas that were intended to be conveyed.<sup>8</sup>

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<sup>7</sup> Stunt: 156.

<sup>8</sup> Scheib: 31.

Hardy's poetry has been described as "difficult to approach"<sup>9</sup>, "rugged"<sup>10</sup>, and with an "idiosyncratic style."<sup>11</sup> His direct language seemed unpolished to many of his contemporaries (and later composers seeking to set his poetry). His poetry is filled with coined words and grammar that, not only reflect his native Dorset dialect, but also served as a reaction against contemporary poetry. Hardy's rhythms and meters included hesitations, sudden speeds, and pauses that are almost silences. His innovative use of such metrical schemes, according to Scheib, "seems to represent the directness of thought."<sup>12</sup> In his research on Hardy's meters and Victorian prosody, Dennis Taylor explains: "As far as I can see, Hardy invented more verse forms than any other poet in the accentual-syllabic tradition... in 1,093 poems he uses over 790 metrical forms of which he invented well over 620."<sup>13</sup> This particular characteristic of Hardy's writing demonstrates Finzi's genius and skill for text setting.

Gerald Raphael Finzi was born 14 July, 1901 in London to John Abraham (Jack) Finzi and Eliza Emma (Lizzie) Finzi *née* Levenson, of Italian and German Jewish descent. Because his father was a successful shipbroker, Finzi enjoyed the security of a well-established family of middle-class comfort in St. John's Wood, an affluent suburb of London. Nonetheless, Finzi had a troubled childhood. Joy Finzi, the composer's wife, reported that Gerald was "an unwanted addi-

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<sup>9</sup> Scheib: 30.

<sup>10</sup> Ibid.

<sup>11</sup> Ibid.

<sup>12</sup> Ibid.

<sup>13</sup> Dennis Taylor, *Hardy's Metres and Victorian Prosody* (Oxford, Oxford University Press, 1988): 71.

tion to an upper-nursery floor and not welcomed by his sister and brothers.”<sup>14</sup> He was exposed to the pitiless reality of death from a very young age. Jack Finzi died of cancer of the roof of the mouth shortly before Gerald’s eighth birthday. All three of Finzi’s brothers were dead by the time he turned eighteen. Douglas succumbed to pneumonia in 1912, Felix committed suicide in 1913 and Edgar died in action, in World War I, in 1918. September of 1918 also saw the death of Ernest Farrar, Finzi’s composition tutor, mentor, and friend, who died after only two days fighting on the front lines. The trauma of losing his hero thus, following the deaths of his father and brothers, marked young Finzi for life.

Finzi’s reaction to multiple losses was to turn to literature and poetry. Literary forces would come to shape his life. Following the upsetting events of his childhood, his choices of poetry “reveal his concerns about human mortality, the inexorable passing of the years, and the urgent personal question of whether he would have time to complete the music he felt he had in him to write.”<sup>15</sup> Poetry became his greatest interest; he turned to it for comfort and intellectual stimulation.

After Farrar had been called to military duty in 1916, Finzi began to study with Edward C. Bairstow, organist of York Minster. Although his time with Bairstow was short, Finzi was strongly influenced by Bairstow’s philosophies of text setting. Bairstow believed that since the words were written before the music and inspired it, the music “should not be merely put onto the words, but pervade them.” In 1919 Finzi went to the Glastonbury Festival and heard a performance of Ralph Vaughan Williams’ *On Wenlock Edge*. This experience not only inspired him

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<sup>14</sup> Scheib: 11.

<sup>15</sup> Stunt: 161.



musically, but began a lasting friendship and mentorship with Vaughan Williams. Finzi later moved to London to study with R. O. Morris. In Morris' studio he met a fellow student of composition, Howard Ferguson. The friendship and support of both Ferguson and Vaughan Williams became important nurturing forces in his life. Bairstow had introduced Finzi to the works of Ivor Gurney: The song *Sleep* was a significant model for Finzi's songwriting career. From the mid-1920s, together with Marion Scott and Howard Ferguson, he began a lifelong campaign to bring attention to Gurney's music, by compiling, editing, and preparing Gurney's disorderly manuscripts for publication.

In 1933, Finzi married Joyce Black, an artist, amateur musician and an unfailing supporter. According to Howard Ferguson, "Joy was the best thing that ever happened to Gerald."<sup>16</sup> Gerald and Joy Finzi had two sons together: Nigel and Christopher. Following a brief, unpleasant teaching experience at the Royal Academy of Music, he moved his family to a home at Church Farm outside of Newbury called Ashmansworth. Ashmansworth became home to the Finzis for the rest of their lives.

In 1951, Finzi was diagnosed with Hodgkin's Disease (now known as Hodgkin's Lymphoma) and was told he had at most ten years to live. Five years later at the Three Choir Festival, while showing Ralph Vaughan Williams the location that inspired his Christmas scene *In Terra Pax*, he was invited to tea by the church warden, whose children had the chicken pox. Finzi's weakened immune system was unable to fight off the infection, and he died on 27 September, 1956.<sup>17</sup>

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<sup>16</sup> Scheib: 14.

<sup>17</sup> Biographical information from Diana McVeagh's *Gerald Finzi: His Life and Music* and Stephen Banfield's *Gerald Finzi: An English Composer*.

Gerald Finzi and Thomas Hardy led very different lives. Hardy's life was unusually long, and his output was tremendous. Finzi was only fifty-five when he died and because his work ethic was exhaustive and methodical, his list of completed works is relatively short. The majority of Finzi's Hardy settings were written before he was thirty-five, and yet the Hardy poetry that Finzi admired dates from the last third of Hardy's life. Finzi at a young age was captured by the attitudes and musings of the older man.

Finzi's and Hardy's similarities were mostly thematic and ideological. They both distrusted dogma, detested war, loved nature, grieved over suffering, believed that creativity was more important than fame or wealth, and shared an awareness that there would never be enough time to complete all that they had to say. Both Finzi and Hardy shared obsessions about the fragility of human existence and the inescapable tyranny of time. They shared an astute sensitivity to words, rhythms and inflections in poetry. They both maintained an unchanging artistic style throughout their lives and are viewed as representative of an earlier age (Hardy's rugged style had a counterpart in Finzi's refusal to embrace 20th century compositional trends). Because the young Finzi experienced so much death and fear of the inability to complete his work, and because Hardy regretted many choices, the artistic works of these two minds intertwine and reach a consensus of purpose and theme. For Finzi, the similarities outweigh the differences. Scheib asks the reader to "Recall that it was the words that chose [Finzi]; Hardy's poetry, which came out of his own life experience, spoke to Finzi in such a fundamental way that he felt compelled to join his own voice to Hardy's. There could be no closer bond."<sup>18</sup>

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<sup>18</sup> Scheib: 33.

Finzi's obsessions with the frailty of human existence and the indomitability of time is not simply a byproduct of his love for the poetry of Thomas Hardy. In Finzi's list of compositions exist many settings of other poets that demonstrate this very theme. Of the seventeen poems that he, as a young man in his early twenties, set between 1921 and 1926, twelve were primarily concerned with human mortality. His earlier works that address the passage of time and the certainty of death on texts by such poets as Bridges, Davies, Peele, and Shakespeare demonstrate that Finzi often chose texts by poets other than Hardy to express this theme. Both Finzi's and Hardy's sensibility for the inevitable passage of time is not completely pessimistic. Both poet and composer share an occasional positive or philosophical spin to the theme. Hardy's poem *Proud Songsters*, set by Finzi for his collection of Hardy songs: *Earth and Air and Rain* typifies this. The poem illustrates the poet's acceptance of the naturalness of death, acknowledgement that change for the better sometimes grows from decay, and hope for the future.

The thrushes sing as the sun is going,  
And the finches whistle in ones and pairs,  
And as it gets dark loud nightingales  
    In bushes  
Pipe, as they can when April wears,  
    As if all time were theirs.

These are brand new birds of twelvemonths' growing,  
Which a year ago, or less than twain,  
No finches were, nor nightingales,  
    Nor thrushes,  
But only particles of grain,  
    And earth and air and rain.<sup>19</sup>

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<sup>19</sup> Thomas Hardy, *Poems of Thomas Hardy* (London: Penguin Classics, 2007): 78.

This poem's acknowledgement of the natural and positive passing of time touched Finzi so much that he used his setting of the poem as the final song of his collection and took the final line as its title.

In 1939 Gerald and Joy Finzi placed a time capsule under their house at Ashmansworth. Within the capsule Finzi placed the text to the James Elroy Flecker's poem *To a poet a thousand years hence*. The poem effectively illustrates both Finzi's state of mind regarding his perceived rapport and relationship with Thomas Hardy, as well as his consummate desire for his own work to be remembered by future generations.

I who am dead a thousand years,  
and wrote this sweet archaic song,  
Send you my words for messengers  
The way I shall not pass along

Since I can never see your face  
And never shake you by the hand,  
I send my soul through time and space  
To greet you. You will understand.<sup>20</sup>

In the preface to his catalogue of works, titled "Absalom's Place," Finzi expounded on his desire to be remembered by future generations and his fear of being unable to complete his life's work. After receiving his cancer diagnosis in 1951, he made some additional edits to the preface. He wrote:

Yet some curious force compels us to preserve and project into the future the essence of our individuality... The artist is like the coral insect, building his reef out of the transitory world around him and making a solid structure to last long after his own fragile and uncertain life... the pressing forward of new generations, will soon obliterate my small contribution. Yet I like to think that in each generation may be found a few responsive minds, and for them, I shd still like the

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<sup>20</sup> James Elroy Flecker, "To a Poet a Thousand Years Hence," *The Clock of the Years: A Gerald and Joy Finzi Anthology*, ed. Rolf Jordan (Lichfield: Chosen Press, 2007): 161.

work to be available.... the affection which an individual may retain after his departure is perhaps the only thing which guarantees an ultimate life to his work.<sup>21</sup>

Finzi and Hardy both shared a fear of ultimate failure. Stunt notes: “It is against this background that one has to view Finzi’s powerful urge to set so many of Hardy’s poems. It is remarkable that something like two-thirds of all Hardy’s poems, and nine-tenths of all Finzi songs, directly or indirectly concern the implications of the relentless march of Time.”<sup>22</sup>

Hardy was as interested in music as Finzi was in poetry. Hardy’s grandfather, father and uncle had been involved in the musical life of the parish church at Stinsford. His father played the fiddle and taught Hardy to play as a child. Hardy continued practicing the fiddle while studying architecture in London in the 1860s. He could still play old dance tunes on his violin when he was 78 years old. Hardy’s love of music directly influenced his novels and poetry, which contain a generous amount of musical imagery. More than a quarter of his poems incorporate references to music, singing, dancing, an instrument or a performer. A significant number of his poems reflect musical forms in their metric schemes (country dance rhythms, variations, hymn tunes—he occasionally used the structure of a hymn tune as an ironic statement of his own agnosticism).

Hardy often employed neologisms, biblical references, archaisms, and Dorset dialect words in his poetry—An attribute that, according to Stunt, “do not merely extend and colour his vocabulary, they also, by association or allusion, recall visions and experiences from older worlds and different social milieux.”<sup>23</sup> In *The Clock of the Years* Hardy uses the word “‘smalled’

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<sup>21</sup> Gerald Finzi, *Absalom’s Place* (London: Boosey & Hawkes, 1941): Preface.

<sup>22</sup> Stunt: 164.

<sup>23</sup> Stunt: 157.

as the aorist of the archaic verb 'to small', meaning to make or become small"<sup>24</sup> to describe the shrinking of the poet's beloved after asking a spirit to turn back time:

Still less in mien  
To my great sorrow became she slowly,  
And smalled till she was nought at all  
In his checkless griff;  
And it was as if  
She had never been.<sup>25</sup>

In *Waiting Both*, as the poet explains to a star his intention to wait for death, Hardy makes reference to the Book of Job, chapter 14, verse 14, which reads: "If a man die, shall he live again? all the days of my appointed time will I wait, till my change come." Hardy was twenty-one years old when a sermon on this text made a lasting impact.

The mastery over Hardy's complex metrical schemes makes Finzi stand out among composers who chose to set Hardy's poetry. Hold elaborates:

It can never be said of Finzi that he shirked his task in his choice of Hardy's lyrics. Most composers have confined themselves to the more pliant lyrics and ballads, such as 'Weathers', 'Her song', 'The market girl', or 'The oxen'. Finzi tackled some of these, but in addition chose 'tremendous and unlikely poems' (Ferguson, 1968), such as 'Channel firing' and 'He abjures love' (both in *Before and After Summer*), 'At a lunar eclipse' (*Till Earth Outwears*) and 'The clock of the years' (*Earth and Air and Rain*), all poems which, to most composers, would appear to be impossible to set. In his three main songbooks and particularly in *Earth and Air and Rain*, he effectively balances 'big' poems with lighter lyrics in a satisfying way.<sup>26</sup>

In a lecture on Hardy, Finzi said:

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<sup>24</sup> Ibid.

<sup>25</sup> Hardy: 124.

<sup>26</sup> Hold: 404.

In theory, setting overly simple, hymn-like, meters could lead to too much potentially boring symmetry, but in practice the challenge for the composer lies in coping with Hardy's more elaborate metrical and rhyming schemes, and the way he has, even in the simplest of stanza forms, of setting up expectations of regularity in order to bring his point more forcefully home to the reader when the expectation is frustrated.<sup>27</sup>

Unlike many song composers, Finzi was wholly faithful to Hardy's texts. Finzi never changed or reordered phrases, nor even repeated a single word of text unless Hardy repeated it as well. He did occasionally change titles of poems the better to suit his interpretation. In *Earth and Air and Rain* three examples exist. The Phantom was originally called The Phantom Horse-woman. Finzi likely changed the name to maintain the element of surprise and drama in the song when Hardy's "ghost-girl rider" is revealed. In a Churchyard was originally While Drawing in a Churchyard, and So I Have Fared is the first phrase of the final stanza of Hardy's self-deprecating poem After Reading Psalms XXXIX, XL, etc.

Trevor Hold accurately describes Finzi's skill for setting English text:

But it is Finzi's genius for word-setting which most claims our admiration. Even at the most basic level of scansion, Finzi can instruct us. His genius lies in his subtle handling of rhythm: the imaginative way in which he translates verbal rhythm into musical rhythm. This can be observed from a glance at the score of any song, which will reveal his enormously wide range of note duration. His bass lines may be stiffly static, but his vocal lines are full of variety; rarely does he reproduce the same rhythm from one bar to the next. This rhythmic flexibility—some might say finickiness—enables him to set words with great delicacy, lending his songs the quality of intimate conversation. One has only to follow the poet's original text when listening to a Finzi setting to appreciate this. Such rightness and beauty of scansion is a joy in itself and, in one respect, achieves the melo-poetic ideal. No wonder he has been called the 'poet's composer'.<sup>28</sup>

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<sup>27</sup> Gerald Finzi, *The Composer's Use of Words* (Crees Lectures at the Royal College of Music in May, 1955—Christopher Stunt, in *Finzi & Hardy*, adds the subscript: "I am indebted to Christopher Finzi for kindly supplying me with a slightly abbreviated typescript of these lectures."): 174.

<sup>28</sup> Hold: 398.

Scheib explicates Finzi's process of reading poetry for enjoyment, and receiving musical inspiration as a byproduct of that reading: "Finzi did not read poetry to find texts to set to music, he read poetry because he genuinely liked to. The musical ideas that he stored in his desk were generated by that reading, by an association of a musical idea with a literary one."<sup>29</sup> Approximately one year before his death, Finzi gave a series of three Crees Lectures at the Royal College of Music under the title, *The Composer's Use of Words*. In one, Finzi explained his deliberate process of reading poetry with music in mind: "Some composers have never written a song or a choral work without at least one line being instantaneously matched with a musical equivalent on the very first reading of the words. That does not make it a work of art, but it is the initial excitement which brings the intellect into play to carry the emotion to its end."<sup>30</sup>

Although a professed agnostic throughout his life, he embraced the English sacred choral tradition. His love of literature led to the bulk of his compositional output being either solo voice or chorus. Any discussion of Finzi's music tends to focus on the literary element and his rare ability with text setting. In 1956, following Finzi's unexpected death, Arthur Bliss, scholar and music critic for *Tempo*, offered the composer tremendous praise: "If a foreigner new to England wished to taste the special flavor of English music, and find where it differed from the music of his own country, he could do no better than study first the music of Gerald Finzi. Here he would come on music that exhales the very air of England."<sup>31</sup>

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<sup>29</sup> Scheib: 19.

<sup>30</sup> Finzi, *The Composer's Use of Words*: 174.

<sup>31</sup> Arthur Bliss, "Gerald Finzi: An Appreciation," *Tempo*, (new series, n. 42, Winter 1956-1957): 5.



Bliss was one of many who felt the need to defend Finzi from critics who dismissed him and his work as old fashioned and out of touch with the trends of 20th century art music. Bliss later acclaimed: "Ashmansworth where he lived was a haven for his many friends. Within the close circle of his wife and two sons he created an atmosphere in which anything sham and insincere wilted. It was the home of a rare poet and a sensitive human being, and the qualities admired in the man are lastingly shown in his music."<sup>32</sup> In his survey of English song composers, Trevor Hold, although unconvinced of his overall genius, admitted: "His care, consideration, and almost aristocratic sensitivity towards his texts, not only in interpreting them faithfully but in setting them in music which follows 'just note and accent', is unsurpassed in English song."<sup>33</sup>

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<sup>32</sup> Bliss: 6.

<sup>33</sup> Hold: 406.